ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 341: Community Theatre for Development - TfD in Practice

Make theatre with a community, not about one

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 300L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Theatre for Development is participatory, research-led and ethically demanding. This pack covers the TfD cycle, key theorists from Boal and Freire to Abah and Etherton, participatory research methods, ethics and consent, and how to document a project honestly rather than claiming impact you did not measure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the TfD cycle from entry to evaluation.
- Apply participatory methods to identify a community's priority issue.
- Design a drama process that invites community participation and ownership.
- Evaluate and document a project with honest evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What TfD is and is not

Development theatre is not a health message delivered with drums.

- Community members are participants and co-authors, not an audience to be instructed.
- The issue must emerge from dialogue with the community, not from the facilitator's assumptions.
- Aesthetics matter; a clumsy play patronises its audience and loses attention.
- Facilitators hold power and must manage it deliberately.
- Sustainability depends on local ownership, not donor enthusiasm.
- Documentation and evaluation are part of the work, not an afterthought.

The TfD cycle

A repeatable sequence keeps the work honest.

1. Entry and rapport building with community leaders and groups.
2. Participatory research: listening, mapping, ranking problems with the community.
3. Analysis and scenario building with local participants.
4. Workshop, improvisation and rehearsal.
5. Performance or intervention with audience participation.
6. Reflection, follow-up and evaluation with the community.

> **Boal's spect-actor**
> Forum theatre invites spectators to intervene in the action. Learn the technique properly rather than asking the audience for 'questions' at the end.

Ethics and honest evaluation

Community work carries obligations.

- Informed consent for participation, filming and photographs.
- Anonymity and confidentiality where individuals are vulnerable.
- Avoid extracting stories for assessment and disappearing.
- Do not claim behaviour change without evidence.
- Record attendance, contributions and follow-up actions.
- Share findings and the final documentation with the community.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 341

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 341 Community Theatre for Development described under popular theatre
- Theorists named: Boal, Brecht, Kidd, Freire, Etherton, Abah, Wa Thiong'o, Colleta
- Practical work requires participation in TfD projects, with performance at the site and audio-visual documentation

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 341 Community Theatre for Development, 3 credits, first semester, 300 level
- THA 261 Theatre in Education and Community at 200 level feeds into it
- THA 369 Theatre and Development Studies appears in the course descriptions

What changed: The 2019 listing makes community theatre a 300-level core after a 200-level education and community course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Community theatre for development remains a 300-level applied core
- Assessment usually includes a field project and a reflective report
- Confirm transport, partner communities and safeguarding expectations before fieldwork

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Who owns a TfD project?

Answer: The community, with the facilitator supporting their process and decisions; not the facilitator or the sponsor.

2. What is forum theatre?

Answer: A participatory form where spectators become 'spect-actors' and intervene in the action to test alternative solutions to an oppression.

3. Why is participatory research essential?

Answer: It surfaces the community's own priorities and language, preventing a project that solves a problem nobody identified.

4. Give two ethical requirements for documenting a TfD project.

Answer: Informed consent for participation and media, and protecting the anonymity of vulnerable participants.

5. Why avoid claiming behaviour change without evidence?

Answer: It misrepresents impact, undermines trust and makes the work impossible to evaluate or repeat honestly.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read one TfD case study and summarise its cycle.
- [ ] Draft a participatory research plan.
- [ ] Write consent and release forms.
- [ ] Facilitate one improvisation workshop with peers.
- [ ] Document a session with notes, photos and attendance.
- [ ] Write an evaluation plan that names your indicators.
- [ ] Present findings to the group you worked with.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: